stirred in her had only grown with time, but his arm hung at his side, unmoving. “You will work here every day?” He smiled. “How can I be so fortunate?”

“Josef, can I ask you . . .”

He leaned forward, his weight shifting onto the balls of his feet.

What could she say? The woman who’d never gone on a date, never felt the warmth of a man’s hand in hers, never been kissed. *It’s like looking at the sky at dawn.* She wanted to know if Rose was right—that a kiss stirs the soul. *Just ask him.* Summoning all her courage, she said, “Would you like to kiss me?”

“Would *you* like me to kiss you?” He was so close she could feel his breath warming her face. “I tried once before, and you ran away like you’d seen a ghost.”

She stared. “You did?” How had she not seen that?

He took her hand and lifted it to his lips. His knuckles, chafed and white, the skin cracked from the harsh soap, yet the tenderness of his touch didn’t surprise her. A doctor’s hands, intent on healing. She sensed that, if he could, he would never let her hand go. He was close enough that she could smell him—sharp soap and musky sweat—and something beneath it all. She thought of a sun-soaked meadow, a dress drying on a line, the shallow part of a stream where the light touched the bottom. It was silly but blindingly honest—Josef smelled of sunshine. She laughed.

“What’s funny?” he asked.

“You and me. This. How could . . .” She gripped her hands together, not daring to utter the word that was on the tip of her tongue. “The world is driven by so much hate.”

“Only love can conquer hate.” His mouth grazed hers, his breath warm on her lips. And finally, the kiss she’d waited for so long and with it, a wild, untamed feeling surged in her chest.

Léa’s heart, usually steady, beat with a new rhythm. She had always held her hands tight in her lap, trying to keep everything together, but now they loosened and reached up to touch his face. His kiss filled her with wild wonder. He was leading her somewhere, and with all her heart, she would follow.